

Harvard Business School professor Rakesh Khurana was right on the mark when he defined the conduct of a true professional with these words: “I will create value for society, rather than extract it.” Plenty of members of our economy do exactly that: create value. Value is created by those professions that I identified previously, as well as by the manufacturers of goods, the providers of services, engineers, builders, and on and on—but not by the financial sector.¹⁵ As we learned earlier, money management extracts value from the returns earned by our business enterprises, and in the process of maximizing its own commercial interests, the industry seems to have lost its professional bearings.

Other examples of the harsh consequences of this move away from professional conduct are easy to come by. In public accounting, our once Big Eight (now Final Four) firms gradually came to provide hugely profitable consulting services to their audit clients, making them business partners of management rather than independent and professional evaluators of generally accepted (if loosely interpreted) accounting principles. The 2003 failure of Arthur Andersen, and the earlier bankruptcy of its client Enron, was but one dramatic example of the consequences of this conflict-riddled relationship.

This is hardly a new concern for me. I’ve written much about how the imbalance between business and professional values has invaded journalism, where we see the increasing dominance of “state” (publishing) over “church” (editorial). In recent years, scandals have reached the most respected echelons of the press—the *New York Times*, the *Los Angeles Times*, the *Washington Post*. The legal profession, too, has hardly been exempt from this trend. The imprisonment of two of the most prominent trial attorneys on criminal charges is but one example of how the once-high principles of the professional practice of law have deteriorated, and how the lure of money has overwhelmed the prestige of reputation.

A similar transition has taken place in the medical profession, where the human concerns of the caregiver and the human needs of the patient have been overwhelmed by the financial interests of commerce: our giant medical care complex of hospitals, insurance